



Departamento de
Economía
Universidad de Concepción



Are fishing decisions flexible?

Participation, target, and landing choices in the U.S. West Coast pelagic fishery

Felipe J. Quezada-Escalona

D. Tommasi • I.C. Kaplan • B. Muhling • S.M. Stohs

IIFET 2026 — Tórshavn — Spatial Trade-offs of EBM (Part 2), 20 Aug

NOAA CAFA (NA20OAR4310507) • ANID-Chile FONDECYT Iniciación N° 11250223 • INCAR² CIA250009.

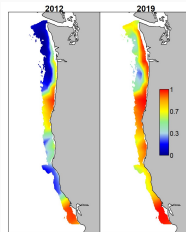
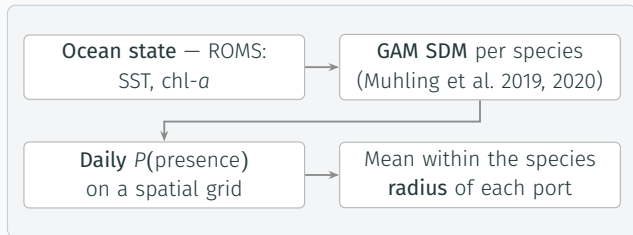
Motivation

- Species distributions are **shifting** with changing ocean conditions — while fishable area shrinks (closures, offshore wind).
- For management, what matters is not the shock but how fleets **redistribute effort** — follow, switch species, switch ports, exit.
- **But** location-choice models take **one fishery at a time**: the **species-targeting** margin drops out *by construction*.
- **Research question**: how do **availability, prices, costs, weather** shape the **daily** joint choice to **participate, target a species** and **land at a port**? *How much flexibility do vessels actually have?*

Spoiler: where the boats end up is produced by **which species they can switch to**.

The contribution: an oceanographic SDM as the economic regressor

SDMs built by **oceanographers** for *ecological* purposes; their daily output is the central covariate in our **discrete-choice model of fishing behavior**.



Illustrative — Chasco et al. (2022)

$Avail_{p,s,t}$: an **exogenous**, gap-free measure of availability for each port $\times$ species $\times$ day $\Rightarrow$ **enters the fisher's utility directly**

Assumption: habitat suitability tracks **potential catch rates** — if only partly, the availability effect is attenuated.

Past catch

- ✗ **Endogenous** — where vessels already *chose* to fish.
- ✗ **Selection bias** — only at fished sites (Chen et al., 2023).
- ✗ **Gaps** — undefined when nobody fishes.

SDM habitat index (ours)

- ✓ **Exogenous** — an environmental input.
- ✓ **No gaps** — a value for *every* port-day.
- ✓ **Counterfactual-ready**.

Setting — four fleet segments, four portfolios

U.S. West Coast Coastal Pelagic Species fishery: squid, sardine, anchovy, mackerels (+ non-CPS crab, salmon, tuna); purse seine. Segments from cluster analysis (Quezada et al., 2024, CJFAS).

Fleet segment	Main target(s)	Trips <i>N</i>	Vessels/yr
S. CCS industrial squid spec.	Market squid	29,160	42
Roving squid–sardine gen.	Squid & sardine	6,806	14
PNW sardine specialist	Pacific sardine	2,581	6
S. CCS forage-fish diverse	Diverse CPS	2,481	5

Same shock, **different portfolios** — the unit of adaptation is the *fleet segment*.

The model — nested logit over *participate* × *target* × *port*

Utility of alternative $j = (p, s, l)$ for vessel i on day t :

$$U_{itj} = \delta_j + \beta_{1,s} \text{Avail}_{tj} + \beta_{2,g} \text{Price}_{tj} + \dots + \varepsilon_{itj}$$

- **Avail** = the daily **SDM** index from the previous slide.
- Also: price, distances, wind, closures, unemployment.
- **State dependence** (last 30 days): processor ties / port capacity.
- Nests: **participation**, then **species** — except forage-diverse, which nests by **port**.
- Crab/salmon split off (costly gear switch).
- Dominant species = target (**93.6%** of revenue).

What drives the choice? Availability coefficients by segment

Availability of...	Squid spec.	Roving gen.	PNW sardine	Forage diverse
Market squid	+2.45***	+1.75***	—	+1.61*
Northern anchovy	+1.35***	+4.19***	+1.16***	−1.88***
Pacific sardine	−1.78**	0.23	−0.59**	0.23
Chub & jack mackerel	−3.94***	−1.48	0.87	−1.92***
Non-CPS (crab/salmon)	—	+5.74***	+10.3***	—
Expected price (CPS/tuna)	0.26	+4.60***	+3.21***	+0.72***
State dependence (30-day)	+2.63***	+2.86***	+2.26***	+3.09***

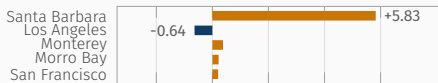
Wind, distance-to-catch, distance-to-CG all (−); unemployment (+). Negative anchovy for forage-diverse: anchovy–squid availability correlate $r = -0.29$. Mackerel is negative in all three southern segments (*fallback target*).

Habit is **strong** (state dependence ≈ 2.3 – 3.1), yet the **SDM signal survives it**. Flexibility we measure is genuine, not inertia.

Move the habitat field, see where the effort goes

Same-season, squid change centroid ($42.99^{\circ}\text{N} \rightarrow 40.66^{\circ}\text{N}$); prices, costs, weather and state dependence fixed.

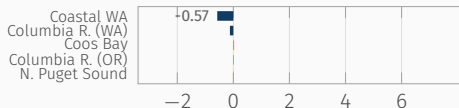
S. CCS squid specialist



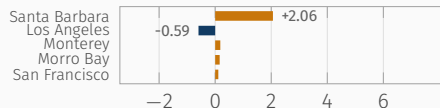
Roving squid-sardine



PNW sardine specialist



S. CCS forage diverse



P(landing at each port), pp: ■ gains effort ■ loses effort

Δ

Δ no-participation: -6.0 / -4.2 / +0.6 / -1.9 pp · same run as Figs. 5-6 of the paper, here by port.

Santa Barbara absorbs the squid. Los Angeles loses -0.6: it *gains* squid but **loses mackerels**. Port aggregate hides a **species recomposition**.

“On the move” vs. “in place” substitution

Adapt *on the move* (species nests)

- Low $\lambda \Rightarrow$ strong correlation across **ports**, same species.
- Anchovy $\lambda = 0.49$; sardine $\lambda = 0.40$.
- $\Rightarrow$ **follow the species across ports.**

Adapt *in place* (port nests)

- Forage-diverse nests by **port**: Santa Barbara $\lambda = 0.49$ vs. LA/Monterey 0.73.
- Substitution across **species within a port.**
- $\Rightarrow$ closest substitute is **another species**, not another port.

Lower λ = alternatives inside the nest are **closer substitutes** ($\lambda = 1$: no nesting). • Terms after Samhouri et al. (2024).

In both cases the aggregate outcome is a **spatial reallocation of effort** between ports, but the mechanism differs: one follows the species, the other substitutes species in place.

Takeaways

1. **Oceanographic SDMs work as economic regressors.** Exogenous, gap-free and daily — and the estimated models predict a **held-out year** well (OOS pseudo- ρ^2 **0.22–0.44** against the null).
2. **Harvesters are flexible.** Participation, target and landing all respond to availability, prices, costs and weather — *even* controlling for strong state dependence.
3. **Spatial redistribution can be explained by species substitution.** Even the fleet that adapts *in place* — substituting **species**, not ports — redistributes effort **in space**.



Departamento de
Economía
Universidad de Concepción



Thank you! / ¿Gracias?

Felipe J. Quezada-Escalona

felipequezada@udec.cl

felipequezada.com

Quezada-Escalona et al. (2026), *Ecological Economics* 247

NOAA CAFA (NA20OAR4310507) • ANID-Chile FONDECYT Iniciación N° 11250223 • INCAR² CIA250009.

Backup • Descriptives — persistence *and* switching

Fleet segment	Species		Ports	
	Switches	Unique	Switches	Unique
S. CCS industrial squid specialist	19.8	2.6	20.7	3.3
Roving squid–sardine generalist	4.6	1.7	9.5	2.7
PNW sardine specialist	3.8	2.4	4.7	2.1
S. CCS forage-fish diverse	10.8	2.4	5.1	2.0

Vessel-level means, 2013–2017. Squid specialist: **switch rate 0.36, median run 2 days** — persistence *and* regular switching.

Short-run **persistence** + frequent **switching** $\Rightarrow$ recent choices matter (motivates state dependence).

Backup • Elasticities — price drives *entry*, availability *targeting*

Extensive margin (participate)

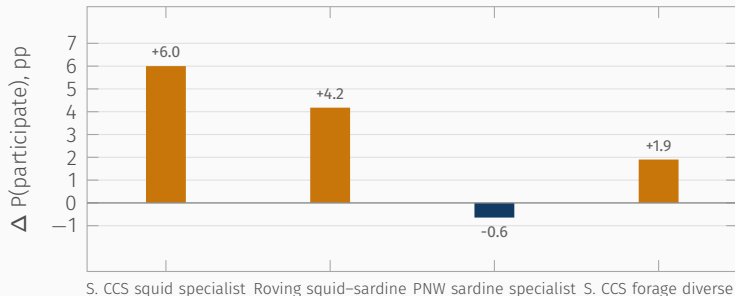
- Price dominates for mobile fleets: squid **1.71** (roving); anchovy **0.43** (PNW).
- Non-CPS availability matters where crab/salmon are relevant: crab **0.24**, sockeye **0.19** (PNW).

Intensive margin (conditional target)

- Availability often $>$ price: anchovy **2.55**, crab **2.12** (roving); crab **3.85**, sockeye **3.71** (PNW).
- Several $> 1 \Rightarrow$ more-than-proportional responses.
- Exception: forage-diverse is **price-driven**.

Prices move participation; **availability** moves which species, once at sea.

Backup • Scenario — change in *participation*

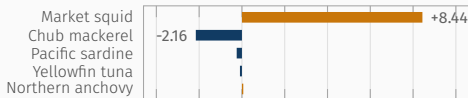


Change in the probability of **participating** (i.e. $-\Delta P(\text{no participation})$) under the same-season window swap (southward squid redistribution). Generated from `scenario_dynamic_same_months_delta_participation_pp.csv`.

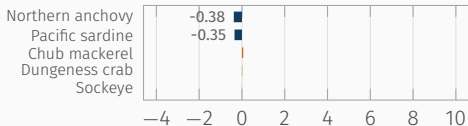
All three southern, squid-facing fleets go fishing **more often** when squid moves toward them; the PNW sardine fleet is essentially unaffected.

Backup • Scenario — change by *target species*

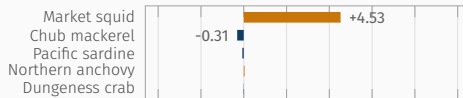
S. CCS squid specialist



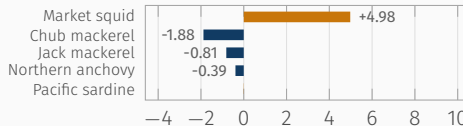
PNW sardine specialist



Roving squid–sardine



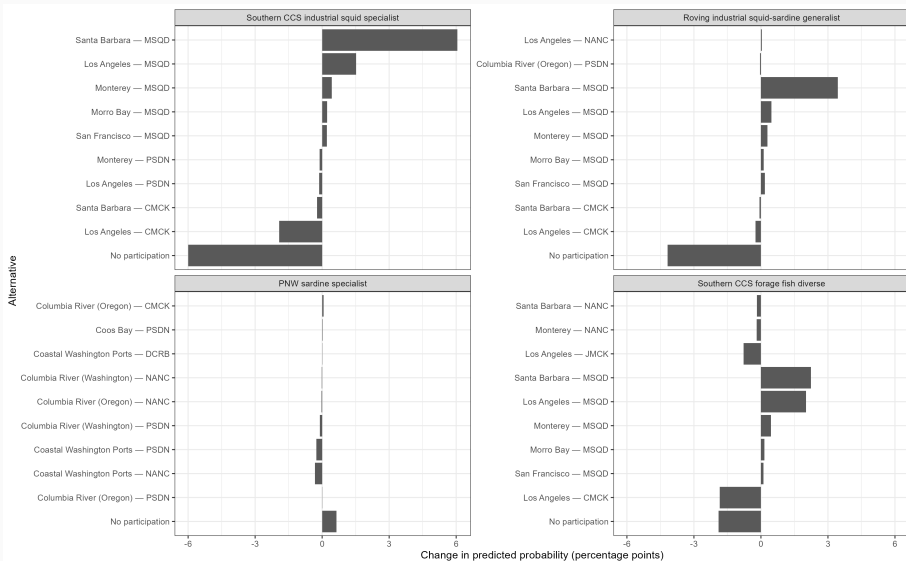
S. CCS forage diverse



Δ predicted probability (pp): ■ more likely targeted ■ less likely · common axis.

Southern fleets **follow the squid** (+8.4 and +5.0 pp), and **mackerel is what they give up** (chub -2.2 and -1.9); the PNW sardine fleet barely moves — it has no squid to follow.

Backup • Scenario — change by port × species alternative



Backup • Dissimilarity parameters (λ)

Nest	Squid spec.	Roving gen.	PNW sardine	Forage diverse
Participation (CPS/Tuna)	0.977	0.752	0.532	0.730
Market squid	0.777	0.752	—	—
Pacific sardine	0.617	0.403	0.404	—
Northern anchovy	0.494	—	0.532	—
Santa Barbara (port)	—	—	—	0.490
Los Angeles / Monterey (port)	—	—	—	0.730

Lower λ = stronger within-nest correlation (more substitution within the nest).

Backup • Variable construction

- **Availability:** binomial GAM SDMs (Muhling et al., 2019, 2020); mean presence within a species radius (60 km sardine/anchovy/mackerel, 90 km squid). CPUE z-score → sigmoid for non-SDM species.
- **Price:** predicted from $\ln(\text{price}) = \alpha + T_y + \gamma_m + \gamma_p$ (year trend, month & port FE); robustness with 30-day moving average.
- **Costs:** Haversine distance port→catch area and port→center of gravity.
- **Weather:** max ERA5 surface wind within 220 km. **Opportunity cost:** state unemployment.

Backup • Limitations

- **Aggregation bias:** port-area resolution may mask finer spatial heterogeneity (Dépalle et al., 2021).
- **Choice-set truncation:** rare alternatives folded into the outside option ($\geq 0.5\%$ filter); IIA assumed for omitted alternatives.
- **Price endogeneity:** predicted / MA prices reduce but do not eliminate simultaneity $\Rightarrow$ interpret price coefficients as **reduced-form** behavioral responses.
- **SDM proxy:** habitat suitability $\neq$ catch rate exactly $\Rightarrow$ availability effect may be attenuated.

Main qualitative result — **availability drives targeting** — is robust across price specifications.